A FOURTH STEP

INVENTORY GUIDE

specifically

for the young adult

"We Made a searching and fearless moral inventory of ourselves."

Each of us comes to a point in our recovery where we need to do some serious work on changing the way we live. We've stopped using drugs, but many of the same destructive living pattrerns continue to plegue us. We find ourselves caught a the web of contradiction and begin to realize that the drugs are only a symptom of our disease. The purpose of the the fourth Step is to begin the process of untangling this web; it is about self-knowledge, self-awareness, and self-respect. There are many ways to approach this Step and there are many published guides available that can help us complete the task. This peticular guide is designed specifically for the young adult in recovery; it is oriented to the life-style and issues of the adolescent addict. Most of us struggle struggle and procrastinate when faced with the prospect of actually coming to terms with who we really are. The only way to begin a written inventory is to actually start writing. If you are unsure about what to do or which approach is best for you, ask your sponsor for direction, and follow his or her suggestions.

GENERAL DIRECTIONS

1. Get yourself a pad of paper or a notebook (loose sheets sheets of paper don't work very well because they tend to get lost or messed up easily) and a couple of pens (not pencils) that you can use only for your inventory.

2. Find a place where you can have some privacy for extended periods of time; someplace where you have a surface to write on, where you wont be bothered or interupted very often, and where there aren't a lot of distractions. (Televisions, radios, and stereos don't mix well with searching and fearless moral inventories; if you have strong feelings about this then it might be a good topic to write about.) You might have to talk to the people you're living with to let them know what you're doing and ask them to help you by respecting your need for privacy; you might even have to find some place outside the home where you can write in peace (a neighbor's house, a church room, the library, etc.).

3. Set aside time in your schedule just to work on your inventory . Plan to write for at least half an hour every day; consistency is important. There will probably be some days when you don't feel like writing or when nothing seems to come out right; take the time anyway (at least a half hour), even if you don't get much accomplished. This is normal, most people work on their 4th Step over a period of several weeks, so don't get discouraged if it's not going as fast as you want.

4. Each time you sit down to write, begin with a prayer ; Ask your Higher Power for help and the courage to be honest and thorough.

5. Start your inventory by taking the first 3 Steps in writing , and review this each time you sit down to write (along with your prayer).

6. Write down whatever comes to your mind. You might want to keep a second pad handy to jot down things that you remember that don't fit in the section you're working on; you can work them in later. Don't try to write the "Great American Novel" , let the thoughts flow the way the come.

7. Don't be overly concerned about your penmanship, but try to make you inventory readable. Don't worry about punctuation, grammar, and spelling, the idea is to explore your life and learn about your morality .

8. Don't Edit ! If something comes out wrong, draw a single line through it and rewrite. Make sure you can read what you crossed out; sometimes what we don't want to put down is very significant.

9. Only use one side of the paper ; save the other for additional thoughts or comments that come to you later.

10. There is no hard, fast rule about how much to write except "You can write too little, but never too much". Write on each section of your inventory until there is nothing more to say; until you feel empty . When you sit down to write you might review the last page or so that you have written; this can stimulate more writing. However, do not go back and reread your inventory again and again; wallowing in your defects and painful experiences is destructive and unnecessary .

11. Each time you finish writing, take the time to thank your Higher Power . Beginning and ending your writing with prayercan help you maintain the proper perspective and relationship to your inventory.

12. The biggest problem people have with the 4th Step is not having made enough progress on Steps 1, 2, and 3. If someone has truely accepted their

powerlessness and the unmanageability of their life, truely believes that a Higher Power can help them, and has truely decided to commit their lives to God's care then they do not need to be afraid of taking a rigorously honest look at their lives. Most of us feel afraid and overwhelmed when we begin the inventory process, this is normal; we're not sure what we're going to find or how emotionally painful the process will be. The best advice that can be offered to anyone beginning a 4th Step inventory is to TRUST GOD .

PRPCESS --

1. Write a history, write down your experience or memories
2. Pick out and list the significient events, events that you feel changed you, your morality, that you think contributed to making you who you are today. Events that you feel guilty about, are embarassed about, that you got very angry about, that scared you, that you've kept secret from someone.
3. For each event look at:
   a. behavior - yours and others
   b. motivation (peer pressure, curisoty, acceptance, rebellion, horse play, to have fun, bordom, obsession, anger, fear, resentment, displaced feelings, etc.) - yours and what you perceive as others
   c. harm - to you and to others (physical, mental, spiritual)
   d. your feelings before, during and after the event
   e. consequences or outcome (physical, mental, spiritual)
4. For each event look at the rule, belief, moral that was supported, broken, or changed; and how the event helped shape who you are

PART II

5. Compare the events (behavior, motivation, harm, feelings, consequence, and the moral - use a chart --

EVENT	BEHAVIOR	MOTIVATION	HARM	FEELINGS	CONSEQUENCES	MORAL

MAJOR CATAGORIES

1. DRUG USE
2. FAMILY
3. ADULTS AND AUTHORITY FIGURES
4. FRIENDS
5. ENEMIES AND COMPETITORS

Church
Clubs

6. SCHOOL
7. JOB OR WORK
8. PLAY (FUN, INTERESTS, ACTIVITIES, ETC.)
9. SEX (EMERGING SEXUALITY)
10. DREAMS AND GOALS